



Story Header



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Chapter Fifty-Three

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ROLLING DOWNHILL

01



TITUS

We find two steel-poled flags between the wreckage of the chapel and the scaffolding, adorned with the pure white sigil of the Afterlife. I instruct Valentina to face them opposite each other, and we roll them in, forming a canvas stretcher we use to scoop Lyra from the fountain.

"I can't use this. No," Lyra says, when I give her the piece of pure Essence to stabilize her. "I would have died for a reason. I can't feel my legs, Titus. I'm useless! I'm not worth it!"

"No. Ullrich was right that the piece of pure Essence is useless to us. It's only useful to keep it from him."

"Why can't you use it?" Valentina asks.

"I can't become a Mask with this thread tethered to my arm."

"Then why don't you tear it?"

"Because I don't know the consequence. And if it does happen . . . who knows how long I'll have after that," I say.

She still hesitates to tap into its power. I'm still dumbstruck at its influence on Valentina.

"Use it," I tell her. "I'm telling you to go ahead."

"But what if—"

"What if, nothing, Lyra! I'm not losing you."

She inspects the celestial pebble within the amulet before she tensions her fingers on it. Valentina used just a little, but it's notably smaller in size, like peeling the skin off a grape. We can feel its influence as I carry the front and Valentina lifts the back.

"What now?" Valentina asks.

"We pray our friends hold fast in the foothills," I tell her. "Ullrich knows that, if his consciousness continues, either I'm still alive or I followed my same series of choices. So all we can do is join the fight below."

I'm surprised that the Royal Guardsmen never show up to capture or kill us. I pray it's because they're occupied at the walls, trying to deter the city's full attack. I pray the Merlot listen to the Vermillion family's warning, though I doubt prayer will get me anywhere that raw effort can't.

"It will take forever to walk back," Valentina says. "She needs attention now."

"I'll be alright. Look, it's working, just a little bit, but it's working," Lyra says. I see her big toe distort the fabric of the flags as she tries to move it.

"That's great, Lyra. But we're not going to be able to take you that way—" I look past a section of wall that was crunched by a chapel column, finding nothing more than a mile of dense, un-traversable foliage dotted with bushes.

"Then how will we make it back?"

There's only one real option. "It depends on if you can drive without crashing," I tell her.



TITUS

"I'm gonna crash!" She shouts.

"No, you're not! Just focus on the road," I insist, as I duck behind the tattered white fabric, scorched with burning holes from the three pearlescent touring cars chasing us. "Gods be damned, this is too fast to not be riding rails—"

"Just hold on. Keep targeting them," Valentina says.

"Ellie barely taught me to fire standing still!"

I couldn't find it in me to kill the guard that was sitting in the driver's seat. It was easy to choke him out since he was younger than me, just a twig: strong from the Essence, but his muscles weren't trained by poverty and hard labor. He must have ratted us off as soon as he came to.

Lyra tries to give me the Amulet, sprawled in the back between the flags.

"No, you need that," I tell her.

"Take it. Just don't let your blood touch it."

Valentina hits a large rock, casting us upwards, and Lyra gets a near second of air time. I nearly disappear out the top before I duck back in, missing a fire blast by the length of my hair. I regain my composure and tighten my hands around the pure Essence, feeling it flow through one arm and out the other.

"Hold steady, Val. Get us steady for a second!" I try to aim, but it's not like throwing a ball. More like peeing in a bush, except the bush is three moving cars with highly-trained, Essenced Guardsmen, and the hose is my arm, churning with such Essence I'm not sure if the next blast will throw me out towards the untreaded road faster than this stolen ride.

Valentina is trying. But the dirt back road snakes left and right. I'm not sure how precise I have to be, whether it will cone short and wide like a shotgun blast, or a direct line of ray energy. The three cars are never together. The only thing that's

constant are the projectile flames pelting to the left and the right of us, and their aim is getting better.

"We're coming up on a straightaway," Valentina says. "They'll all have a direct shot!"

"And so will I," I tell her. "Straighten out, just for a second." I grasp it harder, almost enough to bend the outer shell, and I can feel the energy resonate my entire body at the same frequency, almost enough to make me vomit, aside from Valentina's reckless driving. I hold my breath try to aim, and then I trigger that imaginary muscle that Ellie taught me.

My arm buckles. I hit myself in the face as the Amulet slips from my grasp. For a moment I'm blind, and I consider so much Essence has flooded out of my body that my senses have been destroyed, but I still feel the feeling of inertia — no longer the rugged jostling of Valentina's erratic driving, but only the motion of wind blowing back at my body.

My body thrashes with no surface to ground myself, and when my vision recovers as my ears ring, I realize I'm in the air, at least twenty meters above the lush landscape, heading straight for a bank of pine trees on the side of the road, the flames still sputtering from my palm in stops and starts that shake me as I ragdoll in the air.

It feels as if I'm in an out-of-body experience, watching Valentina's stolen car screech its tires as it brakes for me. As my back crunches the branches, pine needles stabbing my back and scratching my flesh, I cascade down the canopy. The last sight I catch is the crater in the dirt road: three hunks of scorched metal burning as the occupants writhe on the ground.

I grab for a branch. It snaps, and after a face full of needles, I grab again, holding tightly to the stabbing end of whatever's there. The branch swings me downwards, turning all my falling motion into collision with the trunk.

It might have saved my life, but I see stars when my back slams into the rugged ground, bashing my head against the bark of the tree's roots. Despite the bloodied scratches, I'm lucky that I'm mostly unscathed, watching as Valentina approaches from the road to help me to my feet.

The worst pain I feel is my right shoulder socket, my arm thrown back by such tremendous force that it strains on torn muscles. Grasping that branch saved my feet, though I paid for that fall with the headache.

We make it to the end of the only road we know, and the landscape is far more desolate than we left it. Sreaklines of tar denote the path of mindless consumption Endogeny took towards the lower hills, fueling itself with whatever it could acquire in the absence of living flesh. Valentina drives the pearlescent touring car into the hub, directly into the Vermilion lift, and the squealing brakes echo through the vacant chamber lit only by the opposite balcony. When we exit, we find the only other black skid marks not left by Valentina's driving: the desperate last stand of the lowly-Essenced attendant, tatters of his clothes left behind while all his organic matter is elsewhere.

We descend the lift as we watch from the balcony, uncertain of where the Merlot and Carmine's calamitous push advances in the span of a day. The only evidence we have of change is the smell of sulfur — from either distant pockets of flames far across the civilian landscape; gunpowder; or Essence used as a potent replacement for saltpeter.

To the west, the sky flashes in what Valentina and I naively mistake as lightning. Barely able to support herself against the railing with the amulet in her hand, Lyra tells that they're volleys of Essenced Chymaeran energy.

"But that's near the Academy," Valentina says.

"Then that means they're at the first command point. We're getting off," I say.